

No word for Byrd

Veteran Tribe pitcher Paul Byrd still waiting to hear if he'll be disciplined for past-HGH use. **Page C6**



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DOUG CLARKE

'A Few Good Lies,' a lot of ugly scenes

There was the syringe, the bloody gauze, the soda pop can, the DNA, the Nanny Diaries, The Taped Phone Conversation Between BFF: the secrets and lies, the betrayals, the sworn testimony about orders for steroids and HGH (Human Growth Hormone), the mental images of exposed buttocks ...

The "he said, he said ..." "Do you solemnly swear ..." It was all there, inundated we were. On both C-Span and ESPN, Was The Trial of the Century. Except it wasn't really a trial — except in the court of public opinion.

It was fascinating theater, this Congressional hearing, starring Roger Clemens and his accuser, "this McNamee fella."

But as a baseball fan, you cringed at all this stuff about syringes and bloody gauze. Still, you couldn't stay away, either. Was compelling drama. Sort of like going to the zoo and ending up in the reptile building just in time for lunch and seeing the giant boa constrictor swallow the small, soft bunny rabbit with the pink ears. It went on and on. All the "he said, he said."

The Republicans on the House committee — Tom Davis, the screaming Dan Barton, the weepy John Duncan, all perhaps mindful of Clemens' friendship with George Bush I — went hard after McNamee. Maybe also because baseball is a big business and the Republicans when they tuck themselves in at night, nestle up close and intimate with Big Business before wrapping themselves up in a red, white and blue quilt.

The Dems on the panel, meanwhile, honed in hard on Clemens.

At the witness table, Clemens kept blinking rapidly as he spoke. At one point when he vented some anger, panel chairman Tom Waxman told him to be quiet. "This is not your time to talk," Waxman reprimanded. Clemens blinked hard and his neck flushed.

It went on and on some more. Eventually I drifted off ...

Clemens was saying: "Please tell me you have something more than phone bills and foot lockers and 10-year-old gauze ..."

Soon, Clemens was holding court. As it were. In fact, he was on a rant. He was addressing the head prosecution attorney, a fellow named Lt. Kafee.

"Son, we live in a world that has walls and those walls have to be guarded by men throwing fastballs. Whose gonna do it. You? You Chairman Waxman?"

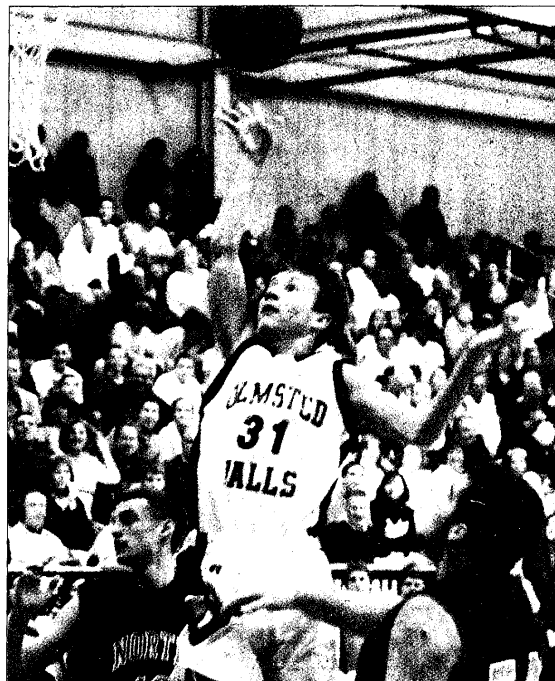
"My existence, while grotesque and incomprehensible to you, saves lives. It wins pennants and championships and Cy Young awards."

Clemens was really on a roll now.

See CLARKE, C2

BOYS BASKETBALL

Olmsted Falls' Jim Brabenecc slips past North Olmsted defenders Nick Brown, left, and Pat Hanrahan during Friday night's SWC showdown at Olmsted Falls. Brabenecc scored a game-high 25 points to help the Bulldogs win their 12th SWC title in 13 years.



CARL SULLENBERGER / CHRONICLE

SWC's top 'Dogs

Chris Assenheimer
The Chronicle-Telegram

OLMSTED TWP. — It couldn't have worked out better for the Southwestern Conference — two backyard rivals playing for the outright league title on the final night of the regular season.

The end result: wasn't too shabby, either.

In front of a packed gymnasium at Olmsted Falls High School on Friday night, Falls and North Olmsted produced an ideal finish to one of the most entertaining SWC

Falls keeps its title by outlasting the favored Eagles in a real thriller

seasons in recent memory, battling to the wire before the Bulldogs prevailed, 74-71.

It was the 12th league title in 13 years for the perennial conference heavyweight, but this one held extra significance, with few picking Falls, the defending champ, to repeat, and the Bulldogs

owning a sub-500 record at the midway point of the regular season.

"I don't know if it is the most special (title), but it's right there with it," said longtime Bulldog coach Pat Donahue, as he wiped tears from his eyes. "No one thought we would win it. People were saying, 'This is an off year for Olmsted Falls.' We were 5-7 and it looked like we were dead and buried."

"But they stayed together and kept coming."

See 'DOGS, C5

DIVISION I SECTIONAL WRESTLING

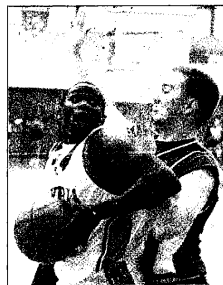
Saints in hunt against St. Ed's

Shaun Bennett
The Chronicle-Telegram

BOZALIN — While a good performance on the opening night of the sectional wrestling tournament can help build confidence, it was a surprisingly human outing by St. Edward that seemed to have 11 other teams at Southview High walking with some spring in their steps.

The Eagles have won 31 straight Division I sectional titles and captured 13 of 14 individual championships last season. They had a 52-point lead after the first night of wrestling last year, yet lead Southview by just 8.5 points heading into today's competition.

See SAINTS, C5



STEVE MANHEIM / CHRONICLE

Elyria's Travis Noble eyes the basket as Brunswick's Ryan Pokorny defends.

BOYS BASKETBALL

Elyria's second-half defense does the job

Tim Gebhardt
The Chronicle-Telegram

ELYRIA — You can almost still hear the chant from the Elyria fans.

"De-fense. De-fense." And the Pioneers responded Friday night, limiting Brunswick to just 11 points in the second half to grab a 54-39 win and a huge momentum burst heading into next week's Division I tournament at Midview.

"They really did a great job of shutting them down," Elyria

coach Bob Walsh said of the Pioneers, who finished the regular season at 14-6, 5-5 in the Northeast Ohio Conference. "Brunswick being as selective as they are about shooting — that helped our defense because Brunswick kids don't force shots. If they don't think they have the shot, they don't take it. I think we kept ourselves close enough to them that they didn't take it. They'd pass the ball up."

See ELYRIA, C5



AP

Daniel Gibson hoists the MVP trophy after scoring 33 points to lead the sophomores Friday night.

NBA ALL-STAR WEEKEND

Bombs away

Cavaliers' Gibson nails 11 3-pointers, scores 33 points to lead sophomores

Brian Mahoney
The Associated Press

NEW ORLEANS — Daniel Gibson walked away with an MVP award, and had the look of someone who has another trophy coming during All-Star weekend.

Gibson made a record 11 3-pointers, many coming right in front of Cleveland teammate LeBron James, and scored 33 points to lead the NBA's sophomore stars to a 136-109 victory over the top rookies on Friday night.

Gibson will compete in the 3-point shootout tonight, and will be hard to beat if he shoots the way he did against the defenseless rookies. He finished three points shy of the game record, set by Amare Stoudemire in 2004.

"My confidence will be high from tonight and hopefully I didn't use them all up," Gibson said.

He had a chance to tie Stoudemire's record, but was short from just inside halfcourt

See GIBSON, C6



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